

Religious Pluralism and Social Change in Nigerian Society

Executive Summary

This report examines the role of religion in shaping social change in Nigeria, based on qualitative responses from a structured questionnaire. The analysis was conducted through thematic grouping of keywords using Python, followed by organization and visualization in Excel. Five main themes emerged, capturing the intersections of religion with diversity, conflict, education, governance, and public sentiment. The findings reveal both the integrative and divisive potentials of religion in Nigerian society, as well as the generational and regional complexities that shape these dynamics.

Methodology

A thematic analysis approach was used to analyze open-ended responses. Python was employed to extract significant keywords, which guided the grouping of responses into five themes: Religious Diversity & Coexistence, Religious Conflict & Division, Religion and Education, Religion and Governance, and Public Attitudes Toward Religion. Each theme was organized into separate sheets in Excel, and analyzed through frequency tables and comparative insights.

Findings and Interpretation

The data shows that many Nigerians experience daily interfaith interactions, especially in urban or moderately diverse communities. However, this surface-level coexistence does not necessarily translate into deeper acceptance; only a minority supports interfaith marriage, and religious institutions are often seen as promoting unity, but inadequately. Regions like Oyo report higher levels of religious tension despite moderate diversity ratings, suggesting that context, history, and governance play significant roles in mediating religious relations.

When it comes to governance, the population is divided. Some advocate for the government's active enforcement of tolerance laws, while others prefer a more neutral stance. However, a significant portion believes that the government already favors one religion, revealing a widespread distrust in institutional neutrality.

Education appears to shape, but not uniformly liberalize, religious attitudes. Most respondents are highly educated, yet views on issues like interfaith marriage remain mixed. Younger participants tend to express more progressive views, but their exposure to religious conflict mirrors that of older respondents, implying that ideological shifts are not always matched by social realities.

Public perception of religion is complex. Most believe religious leaders should be vocal on social issues, and many acknowledge the developmental role of religious organizations in communities. Still, there is division over whether religion can justify social inequality, reflecting broader debates about religion's evolving place in Nigerian society.

Key Insights

The report highlights several paradoxes. First, religious pluralism in Nigeria is widespread but shallow — people interact across religious lines but maintain strong boundaries around issues like marriage. Second, youth are more open in their beliefs but remain structurally constrained by the same challenges as older generations. Third, while many demand government action on religious tolerance, they simultaneously question the state's fairness, pointing to a crisis of legitimacy. Finally, high diversity alone does not reduce conflict; local governance and social cohesion mechanisms matter.

Theoretical Contributions

This analysis challenges and extends several key theories. It refines *Contact Theory* by showing that proximity does not necessarily lead to full integration, especially in intimate domains. It complicates *Secularization Theory*, revealing that religion continues to shape society in fragmented and contested ways. It also highlights the nuanced role of youth — while often seen as agents of change, their lived experiences reflect deeper structural issues.

Recommendations

Researchers and policymakers should approach religious pluralism not as a single-layer issue but as a complex, layered reality. Coexistence at the interpersonal level does not replace the need for institutional fairness and structural protections. Future programs should combine interfaith dialogue with enforceable tolerance policies, especially in regions prone to religious conflict. Additionally, more attention should be given to understanding youth perspectives, not only as a hopeful future but as a lens into current contradictions.